Torque about it

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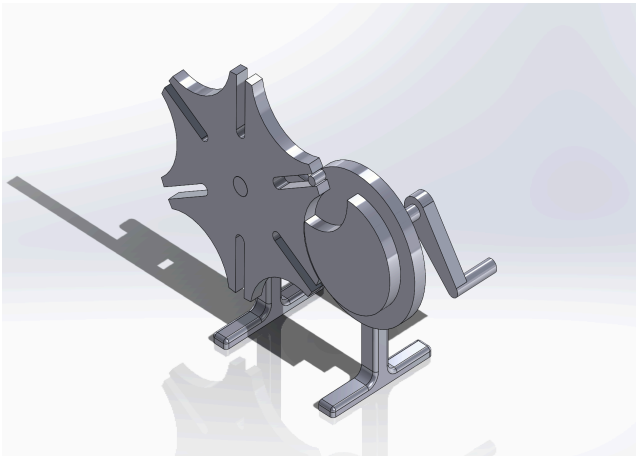
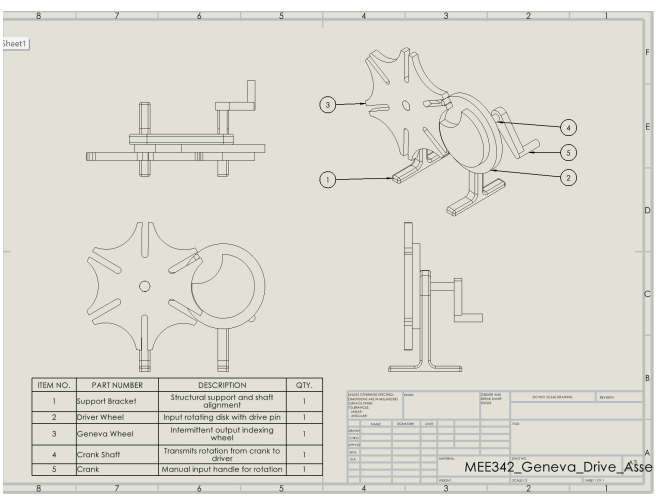
Final Design Overview



The isometric view shows the full Geneva drive assembly and how all of the components are arranged. The mechanism works by taking continuous rotation from the crank and converting it into intermittent motion of the Geneva wheel using a drive pin on the driver wheel. In this design, the Geneva wheel has six slots, so each full rotation of the driver causes the wheel to rotate 60° and then remain stationary for a short period. This view helps visualize how the parts fit together and how the motion is transferred through the system.

Figure 1: Isometric view of the assembled Geneva drive mechanism.

To better understand the individual components and their roles, a labeled assembly and bill of materials are shown below.

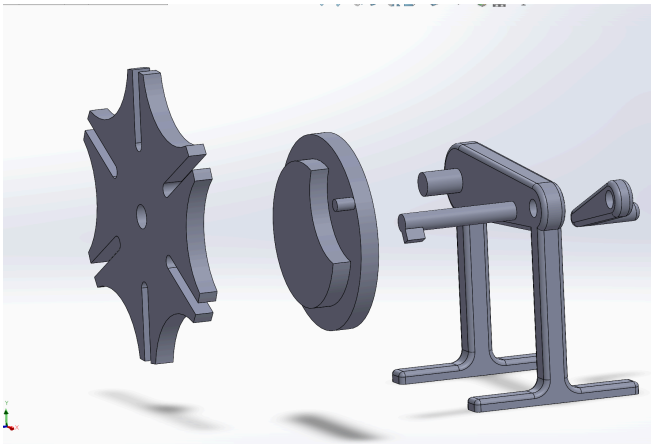


ITEM NO.	PART NUMBER	DESCRIPTION	QTY.
1	Support Bracket	Structural support and shaft alignment	1
2	Driver Wheel	Input rotating disk with drive pin	1
3	Geneva Wheel	Intermittent output indexing wheel	1
4	Crank Shaft	Transmits rotation from crank to driver	1
5	Crank	Manual input handle for rotation	1

The final Geneva drive assembly consists of five primary components: the support bracket, driver wheel, Geneva wheel, crank shaft, and crank. The driver wheel rotates continuously due to manual input from the crank and transmits motion through a drive pin that engages the slots of the Geneva wheel. This interaction produces intermittent motion, where the Geneva wheel advances in discrete steps while remaining stationary during dwell periods. The support bracket maintains proper alignment of the shafts and ensures structural stability of the system. The labeled parts and bill of materials provide a clear identification of each component and its function within the mechanism.

Figure 2: Labeled assembly of the Geneva drive with bill of materials (BOM).

To better illustrate how the components are assembled and how they fit together, an exploded view of the Geneva drive is shown below.



The exploded view shows how each component of the Geneva drive fits together and how the assembly is organized. The support bracket serves as the base and maintains alignment of both shafts. The Geneva wheel is mounted on its own shaft, while the driver wheel and crank are connected through the keyed input shaft to transmit rotation without slipping. During operation, the drive pin on the driver wheel engages the slots of the Geneva wheel to create intermittent motion. This view helps show the assembly order and the relationship between the main components.

Figure 3: Exploded view of the Geneva drive assembly showing component arrangement, shaft connections, and assembly sequence.

Mechanism Operation and Motion Study

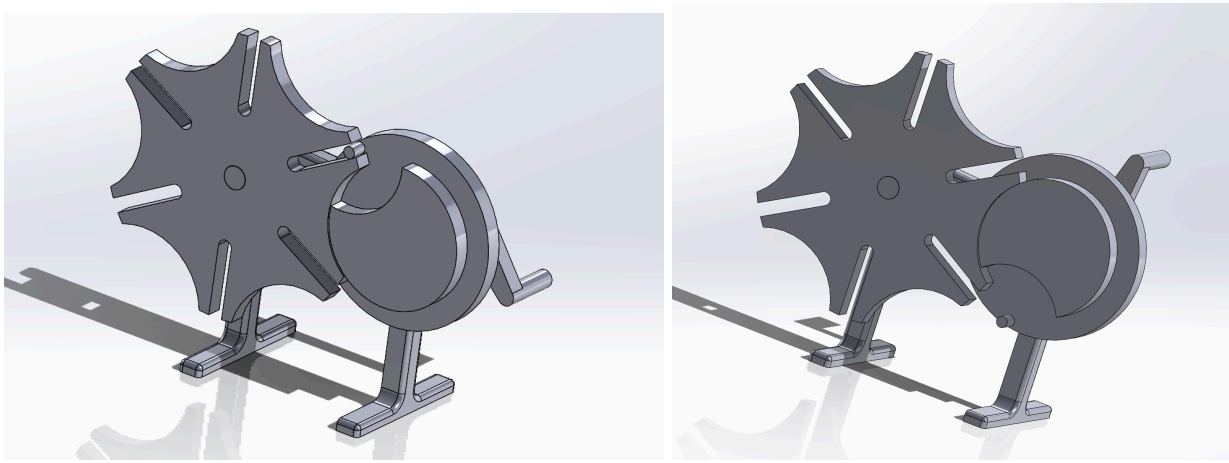


Figure 4: Motion study of the Geneva drive showing the engagement position (left) and the dwell position (right).

Figure 5: Animated motion of the Geneva drive mechanism during operation.

A motion study was created in SolidWorks to demonstrate the operation of the Geneva drive mechanism. A constant rotational input was applied to the crank shaft, causing the driver wheel to rotate continuously. As shown in Figure 4, the drive pin engages with the slots of the Geneva wheel, producing intermittent motion. The Geneva wheel rotates in discrete 60° steps during engagement and remains stationary during the dwell period between engagements. The animation confirms the expected behavior of the six-slot Geneva mechanism and demonstrates proper interaction between the drive pin and the Geneva wheel.

Engineering Analysis

The engineering analysis focused on the critical load-carrying components of the Geneva drive during operation. The most important parts were identified as the drive pin and the input shaft, since these components are responsible for transferring torque from the crank to the Geneva wheel. Structural steel was assumed for all components, and the loading condition was taken at the point of maximum engagement between the drive pin and the Geneva slot. This represents the most critical operating condition because the highest force transfer occurs when the pin is actively driving the Geneva wheel.

Loading Assumptions: To simplify the analysis, several assumptions were made while still capturing the most critical behavior of the mechanism. The Geneva drive was evaluated at the moment when the drive pin is fully engaged in a slot of the Geneva wheel, since this is when the largest forces are transmitted. The applied torque was assumed to be constant at 500 N·mm and fully transferred through the shaft to the driver wheel without slipping. The support bracket was treated as rigid, and the material was assumed to remain in the elastic range. All calculations were performed using consistent units of N and mm, resulting in stresses reported in MPa.

Drive Pin Analysis: The drive pin was analyzed because it directly transfers force from the driver wheel to the Geneva wheel. Using the applied torque and the radial distance from the center of the driver wheel to the center of the drive pin, the force acting on the pin was calculated. That force was then used to determine the shear stress, bending stress, equivalent stress, and factor of safety of the pin. The handwritten calculations are shown in Figures 6 through 10. Based on the results, the drive pin experiences relatively low stress and remains well below the yield strength of structural steel.

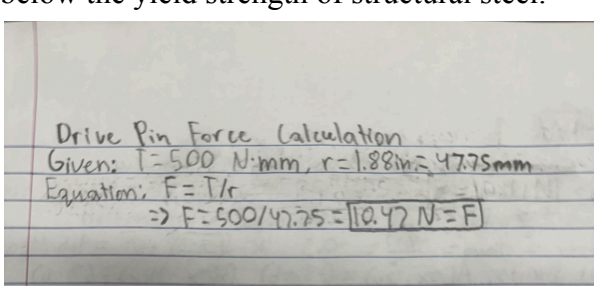


Figure 6: Hand calculation for the force acting on the drive pin.

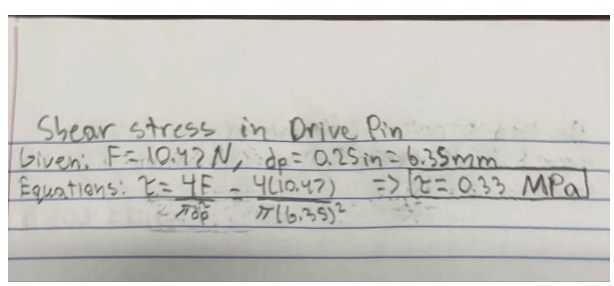


Figure 7: Hand calculation for shear stress in the drive pin.

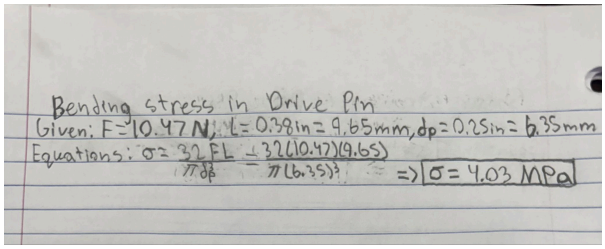


Figure 8: Hand calculation for bending stress in the drive pin.

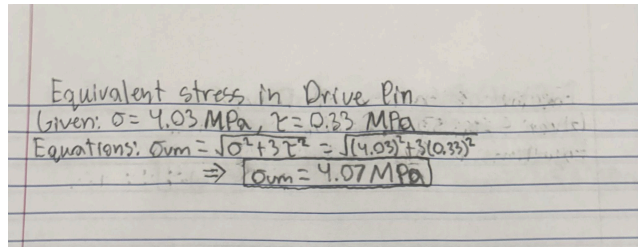


Figure 9: Hand calculation for equivalent stress in the drive pin.

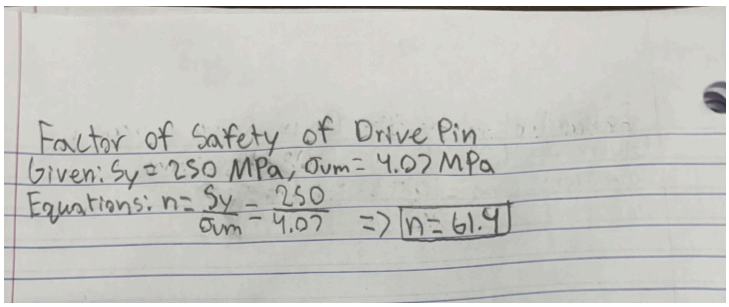


Figure 10: Hand calculation for the factor of safety of the drive pin.

Input Shaft Analysis: The input shaft was analyzed in torsion because it transmits the applied torque from the crank to the driver wheel. The torsional shear stress was calculated and then converted to an equivalent stress using the von Mises criterion. The handwritten calculations are shown in Figures 11 and 12. The results show that the shaft also remains well within safe operating limits.

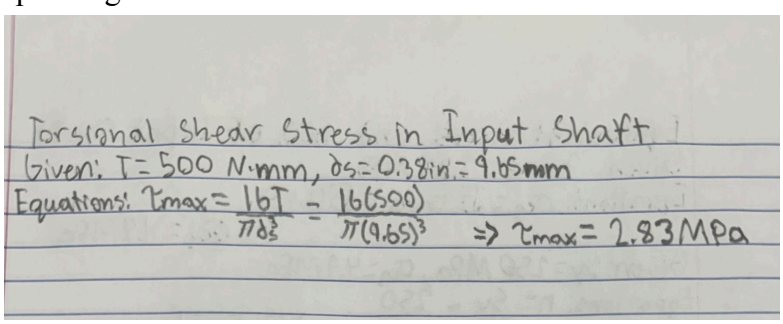


Figure 11: Hand calculation for torsional shear stress in the input shaft.

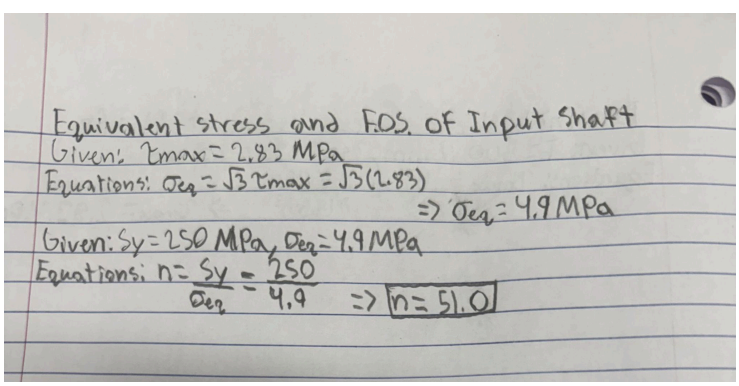


Figure 12: Hand calculation for equivalent stress and factor of safety of the input shaft.

Interface Stress (Pin-Wheel Interaction): The interaction between the drive pin and the Geneva wheel slot results in localized contact stresses during engagement. This interface was indirectly evaluated through the drive pin analysis, which accounted for both shear and bending stresses. While the overall stress levels remain low, localized contact at the pin-slot interface may lead to wear over time due to repeated engagement. This behavior was also discussed in the wear analysis, where stress concentrations at the slot edges were identified as potential areas for long-term degradation. However, from a structural standpoint, the stresses remain well below material limits, and the interface is considered safe under the applied loading conditions.

Fatigue Analysis: The drive pin experiences repeated loading during operation of the Geneva mechanism due to cyclic engagement and disengagement with the Geneva wheel. This results in fluctuating stresses that could potentially lead to fatigue failure over time. Using the previously calculated maximum equivalent stress of approximately 4.07 MPa for the drive pin, the alternating stress can be approximated as $\sigma_a \approx 4.07$ MPa, while the mean stress is assumed to be small due to the intermittent nature of loading. A simplified fatigue analysis using the Goodman criterion indicates that the stress levels are significantly below typical endurance limits for structural steel. Given the relatively low magnitude of stress and the high factor of safety observed in static loading, fatigue failure is not expected to be a critical concern for this design. Therefore, the drive pin is considered safe under repeated loading conditions.

Bearing Load Analysis: The input shaft is supported by bearings that experience reaction forces due to the applied loading. Based on the applied force of 10.61 N at the drive pin, and assuming two support locations, the reaction force at each bearing is approximately 5.3 N. This load is extremely small compared to typical bearing load capacities, which are designed to handle significantly higher forces.

Contact/Wear Discussion: Although the calculated stresses in the pin and shaft are low, localized contact stresses still occur where the drive pin engages the Geneva wheel slot. Repeated engagement at this interface can lead to wear over time, especially near slot edges where stress concentrations may occur. For this reason, smooth geometry, rounded features, and proper clearances are important to reduce long-term wear. The pin-slot interface is the most likely location for performance degradation, even if structural failure is not expected.

Factor of Safety Summary:

Component	**Equivalent Stress (MPa)**	**Factor of Safety**
Drive Pin	4.07	61.4
Input Shaft	4.90	51.0

The calculated factors of safety indicate that both the drive pin and input shaft operate well within the allowable limits of structural steel under the applied loading conditions. The drive pin

experiences the higher stress because it directly transfers force to the Geneva wheel during engagement, making it the more critical of the two analyzed components. Localized wear may still occur at the pin-slot interface over time, but the primary structural components remain safely below yielding.

Global Safety Overview: The analysis identified the drive pin as the most critical component due to its role in directly transferring force during engagement with the Geneva wheel. However, both the drive pin and input shaft exhibit high factors of safety under static loading, and fatigue analysis indicates that repeated loading does not pose a significant risk. Bearing loads are minimal, and all interface stresses remain within acceptable limits. Overall, the design is structurally sound and highly conservative, with the primary long-term concern being wear at the pin-slot interface rather than material failure.

Conclusion of Analysis: Based on the analysis, both the drive pin and the input shaft experience stresses that are significantly below the yield strength of structural steel under the applied torque of 500 N·mm. The drive pin is the more critical component because it directly interacts with the Geneva wheel during engagement, but it still maintains a high factor of safety. Overall, the design is structurally sound, and the most likely long-term concern is wear at the pin-slot interface rather than yielding or fracture.

Finite Element Analysis

Ansys Setup and Boundary Conditions: The drive pin and input shaft were analyzed using ANSYS Static Structural to validate the hand calculations. Structural steel was assigned as the material, consistent with the analytical assumptions. A fixed support was applied to constrain the shaft, and a force of 10.61 N was applied at the drive pin location to represent the equivalent force derived from the applied torque of 500 N·mm. A corresponding moment of 0.351 N·m was applied to simulate torque transfer through the shaft. A tetrahedral mesh was generated, with refinement near the pin connection region to capture stress concentrations.

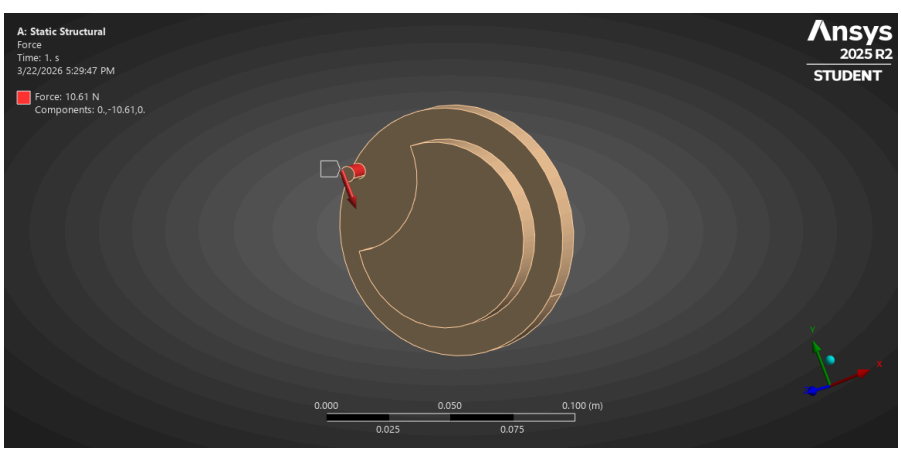


Figure 13: ANSYS boundary conditions showing applied force at the drive pin

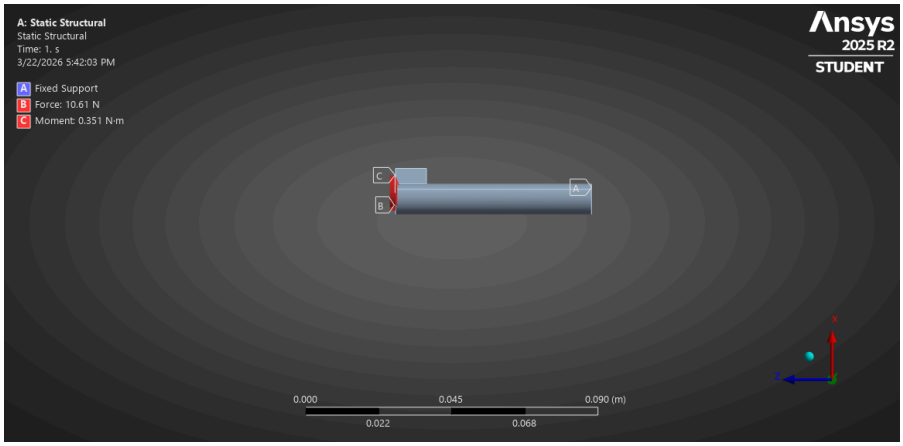


Figure 14: ANSYS boundary conditions showing fixed support and applied moment.

Drive Pin Results: The equivalent stress results show that the maximum stress occurs at the base of the drive pin where it connects to the driver wheel. The maximum stress was approximately 1.26 MPa, which is significantly below the yield strength of structural steel. This indicates that the drive pin is not at risk of yielding under the applied loading conditions. The deformation results show a maximum displacement of approximately 2.60 x 10^{-7} m, which is extremely small and confirms that the drive pin behaves as a rigid component under loading.

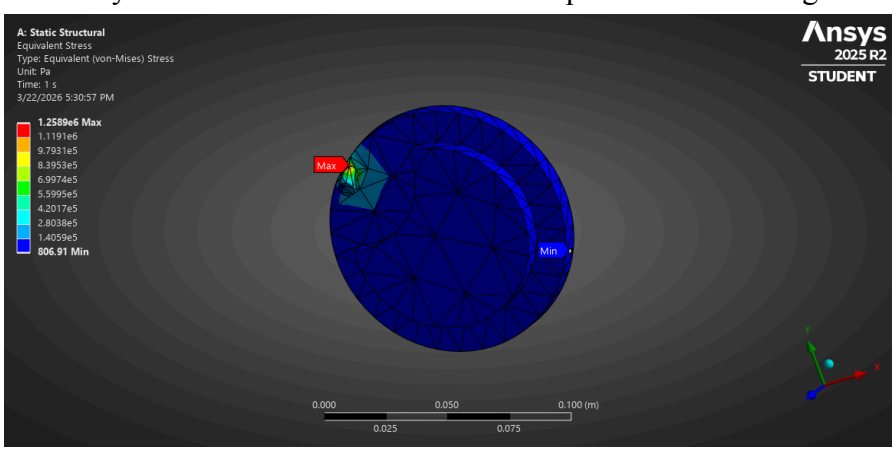


Figure 15: Equivalent stress distribution in the drive pin showing stress concentration at the base.

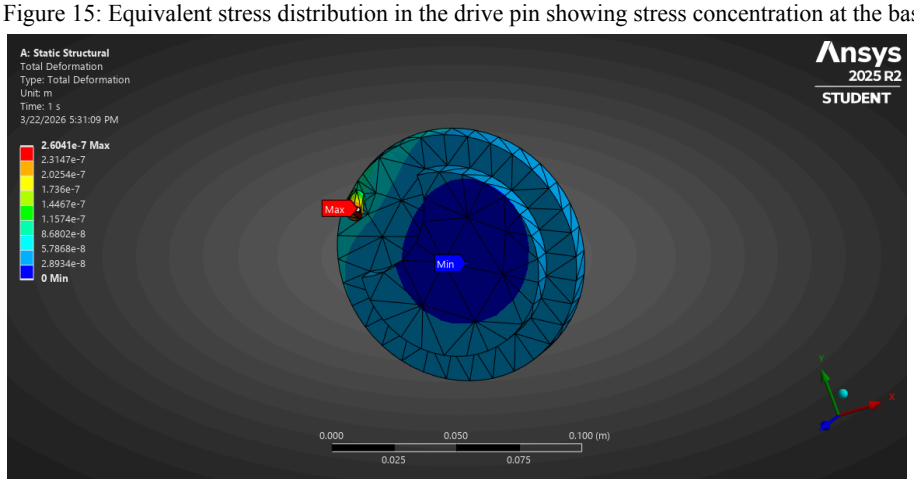


Figure 16: Total deformation of the drive pin.

Input Shaft Results: The input shaft experiences its maximum equivalent stress near the fixed support, which is expected due to the constraint and bending effects. The maximum stress was approximately 7.22 MPa, which is higher than the drive pin but still well below the yield strength of structural steel. The deformation results show a maximum displacement of approximately 1.09 x 10^{-5} m, indicating slight bending of the shaft under load but still within acceptable limits.

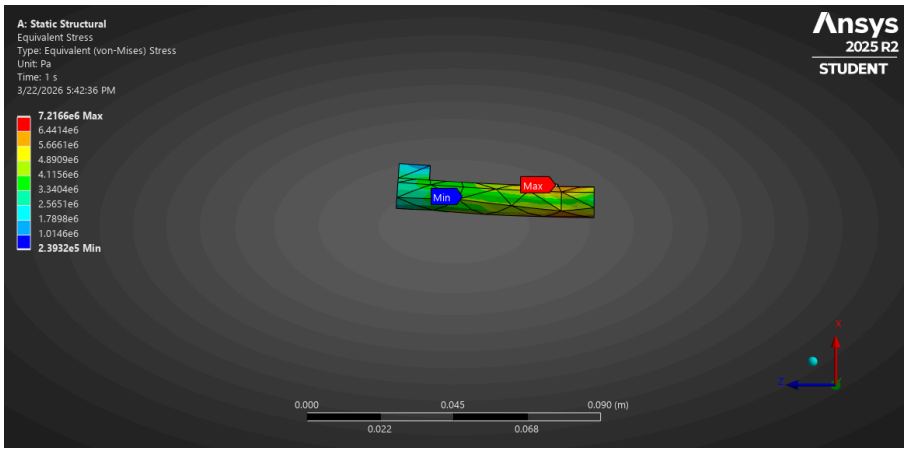


Figure 17: Equivalent stress distribution in the input shaft.

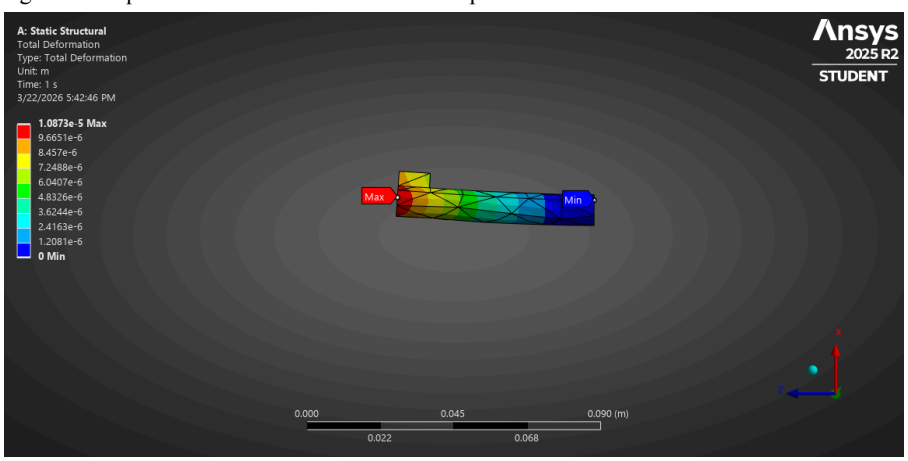


Figure 18: Total deformation of the input shaft.

Factor of Safety: The factor of safety results indicate that both the drive pin and input shaft operate well within safe limits under the applied loading conditions. The minimum factor of safety occurs near the base of the drive pin and at the fixed support of the shaft, which correspond to the locations of maximum stress identified in the analysis. The ANSYS results show a minimum factor of safety of approximately 15, which is the lower bound of the plotted scale, indicating that the actual factor of safety may be even higher. These results are consistent with the hand calculations, which predicted significantly high factors of safety for both components. The difference in magnitude between the analytical and numerical results is due to the simplified assumptions used in hand calculations, such as idealized loading and uniform stress distribution, compared to the more detailed stress concentrations captured in the ANSYS

model. Despite these differences, both approaches confirm that the stresses are far below the material limits. Overall, the results demonstrate that the design is highly conservative and capable of safely withstanding the applied loads.

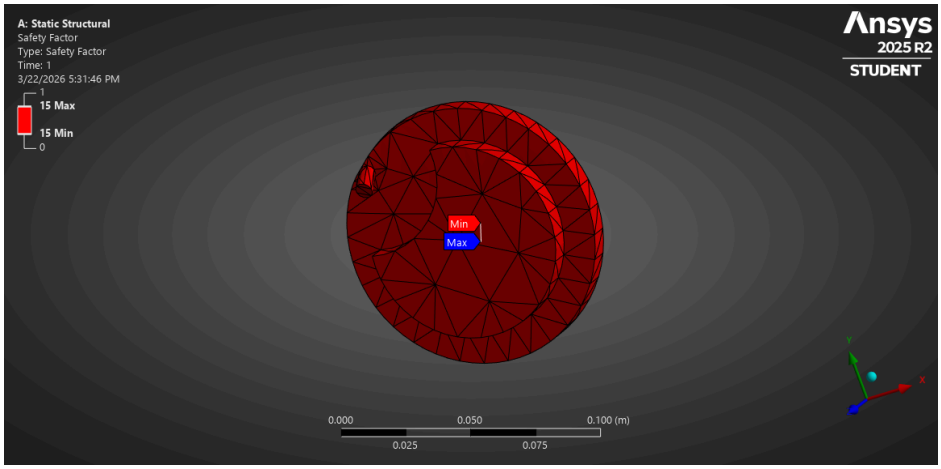


Figure 19: Factor of safety distribution for the drive pin showing all regions well above the minimum allowable value.

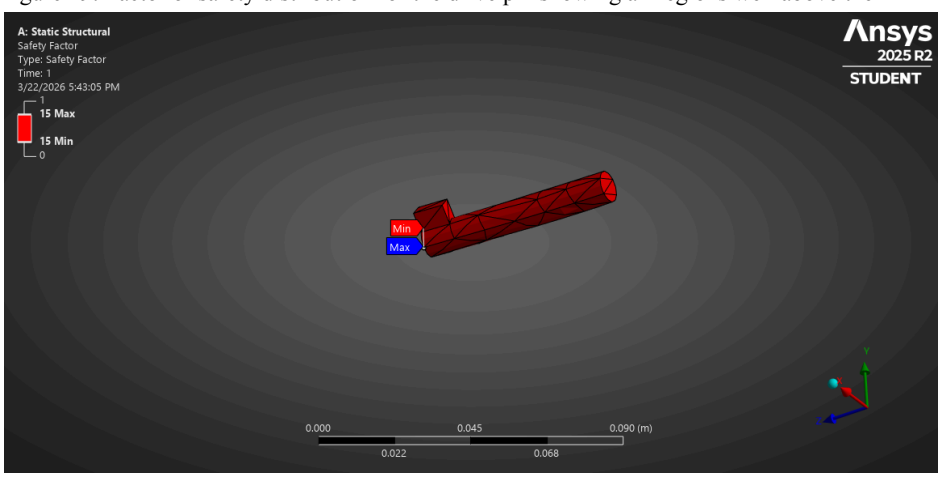


Figure 20: Factor of safety distribution for the input shaft under applied loading.

Model Accuracy: The structural error results indicate that the solution is reliable, with low error values observed throughout most of the geometry. The highest error regions are localized near the base of the drive pin and at geometric transitions, where stress concentrations occur and gradients are highest. This behavior is expected in finite element analysis, as sharp geometry changes and load transfer regions require finer mesh resolution to fully capture stress variations. Overall, the error distribution suggests that the mesh is sufficiently refined to produce accurate results, and no significant numerical issues are present in the solution.

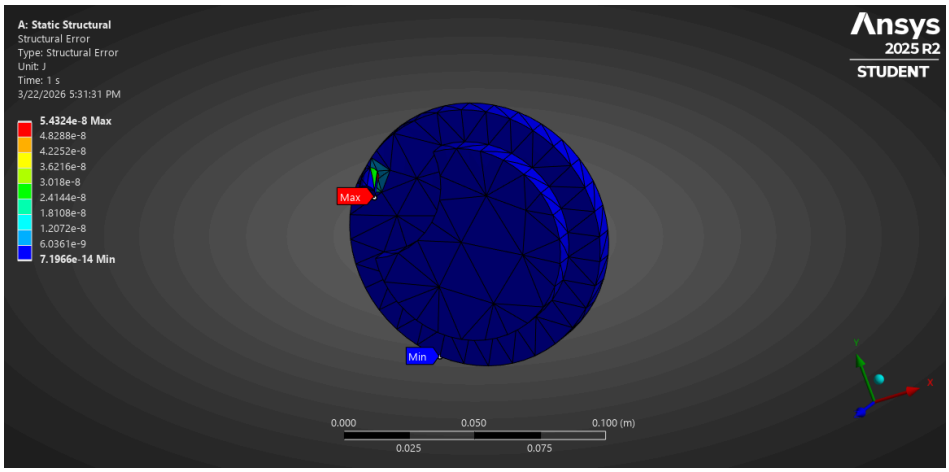


Figure 21: Structural error distribution for the drive pin showing localized error near regions of high stress gradients.

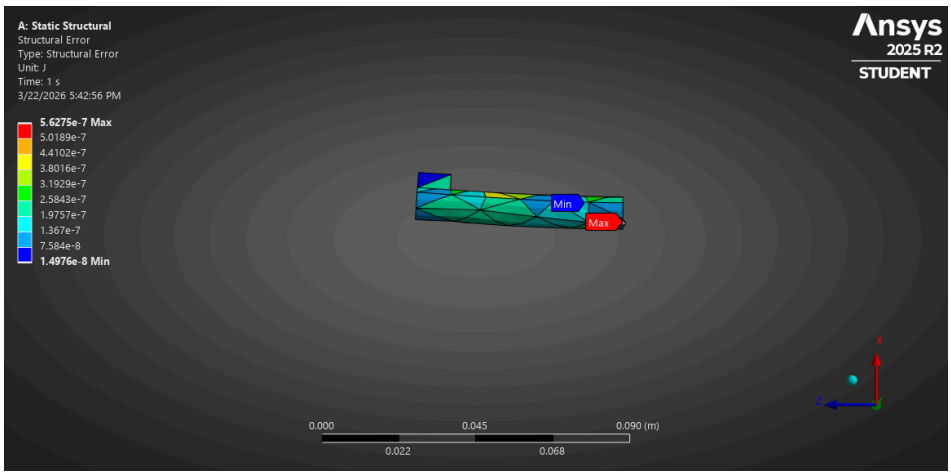


Figure 22: Structural error distribution for the input shaft.

Comparison to Hand Calculations: The ANSYS results are consistent with the hand calculations, as both approaches indicate that the stresses in the drive pin and input shaft are well below the yield strength of structural steel. The hand calculations predicted very high factors of safety (61.4 for the drive pin and 51.0 for the shaft), while the ANSYS results showed a minimum factor of safety of approximately 15. Although the ANSYS values are lower, this difference is expected because the numerical model captures localized stress concentrations at the base of the drive pin and near the fixed support of the shaft, whereas the hand calculations assume idealized loading and uniform stress distribution. In addition, the locations of maximum stress identified in ANSYS match the theoretical expectations, with the highest stresses occurring in the drive pin due to combined shear and bending, and in the shaft near the support due to constraint effects. Overall, both methods lead to the same conclusion that the stresses are significantly below material limits and that the design is structurally safe. The finite element analysis therefore validates the hand calculations while providing a more detailed representation of the stress distribution within the components.

Design for Assembly and 3D printing:

The Geneva drive was designed for easy assembly, consisting of five primary components that can be inserted together with minimal alignment effort. After 3D printing, only minor post-processing is required, including fitting the components and attaching the handle. The geometry was optimized for manufacturing by using flat-facing parts that can be printed with little to no support material. Additionally, appropriate clearances were incorporated into the design to accommodate typical printing tolerances and ensure smooth operation of the mechanism.

Anticipated Risks and Weakness's:

Several potential risks and weaknesses have been identified that will need to be addressed during prototyping. Misalignment between the driver wheel and Geneva wheel may prevent the drive pin from entering the slots smoothly, leading to jamming, increased friction, or incomplete indexing. Dimensional inaccuracies from 3D printing may also result in improperly sized components, causing either excessive interference or insufficient engagement at the pin-slot interface. Wear is expected to occur at the contact surfaces between the drive pin and Geneva slots, particularly at the slot edges, as well as between the Geneva wheel and the locking surface during dwell periods, which may reduce long-term accuracy. Additionally, the Geneva wheel is subject to cyclic loading due to repeated start–stop motion, which may lead to deformation or cracking at the slot ends, especially if stress concentrations are present or if the printed material is not sufficiently strong. These risks will be evaluated and mitigated through prototype testing, dimensional adjustments, and potential material or geometry improvements.